

Reading the evidence

Name	Group	Date
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Safety Rusted nails are sharp and rust carries a tetanus risk. TONGS OR GLOVES ONLY — never bare hands. Count your nails out and count them back in. Tell the teacher straight away if anyone gets scratched.

1 • Drying — and why we are being this fussy

One drop of water weighs 0.05 g. The mass your nails have actually gained might only be 0.06 g. So a single drop left behind could DOUBLE your result and you would never know. Water is not rust, and the scale cannot tell the difference.

1. Lift your nails out with tongs, keeping each jar’s three together and labelled.
2. Rinse briefly under the tap.
3. Blot hard with paper towel. Then blot again.
4. Spread them on your tray and leave them until they look AND feel completely dry.

2 • The numbers

Weigh all three nails together, exactly as you did in Week 1. Record to TWO DECIMAL PLACES, always — 13.80 g, not 13.8 g.

	Jar 1	Jar 2	Jar 3
Mass in Week 1 (g)			
Mass today (g)			
DIFFERENCE (g)			

The check that tells you whether to trust any of it The dry sealed jar should weigh what it weighed in Week 1, give or take a division. If it has GAINED, the drying has failed and every other number in the class is too high.

Did your nails get heavier, lighter, or stay the same?

Is that what you expected five weeks ago? Say what you thought would happen.

Nothing was added to your jar. So where did the extra mass come from?

3 • Graph your three jars

One bar per jar. Write your own scale up the left-hand side — look at your biggest number first and choose a scale that fits it.

Mass gained (g)

Write your scale			
	Jar 1	Jar 2	Jar 3

Are your three bars the same height? Should they be — you set all three up identically?

How different would two jars have to be before you would call it a REAL difference rather than just wobble?

Why we ran three If you had only run one jar, you would have no idea whether your number was typical or a fluke. Three tells you how much your own results wobble — and that tells you how big a difference has to be before it means anything.

Mass gained (g)

Write what each letter stands for:

What the graph says

5. Which condition rusted the most?

6. Which TWO conditions barely rusted at all? What do they have in common — and what is different between them?

7. Compare the half-submerged jar with the fully submerged one. Which won, and were you expecting that?

8. Write the pattern in one sentence. What does rusting need?

Push me Express each gain as a percentage of the starting mass. Does that change which condition won? Then: is the gap BETWEEN conditions bigger than the gap between your own three jars — and what does your answer mean for how much you trust the result?